

Exhausted survivors
An American patrol torpedo boat hoists Japanese survivors out of the water after the destruction of the Japanese forces at Leyte Gulf.

Nishimura's flagship *Yamashiro* was hit but pressed on. At 3:52 a.m. the darkness ahead suddenly erupted as a semicircle of waiting American warships opened fire. The most modern of them had radar fire control that left the Japanese no chance. Nishimura was already dead by the time *Yamashiro* sank.

Approaching this scene of carnage, some way behind Nishimura, a second group of warships under Admiral Shima added an element of farce to the tragedy by colliding with the crippled cruiser *Mogami* and then torpedoing an island misidentified as an enemy ship, before fleeing back down the strait.

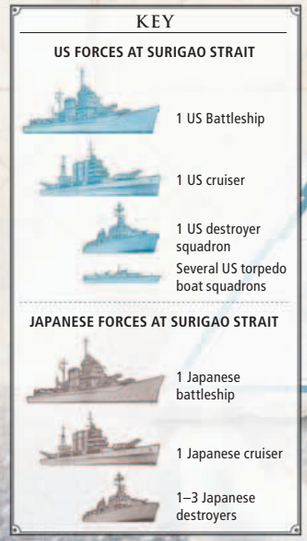
To the north, meanwhile, Kurita led his ships undetected through the San Bernadino Strait and on the morning of October 25 sailed south down the coast of Samar island toward Leyte. First light revealed a force of 16 American escort carriers and seven destroyers and destroyer escorts lying in his path. As the Japanese ships opened fire, Rear Admiral Sprague radioed desperately for help, believing his carriers would be destroyed in minutes. With outstanding bravery the destroyers attacked the Japanese capital ships, winning the carriers a breathing space. All but one were eventually sunk by Japanese guns and many of the carriers took hits. But the destroyers and carrier aircraft between them sank three of Kurita's heavy cruisers and badly damaged three more. Although Sprague's carriers were still theoretically at his mercy, Kurita had had enough and turned back, safely withdrawing the remainder of his ships from the battle.

DESPERATE LAST GAMBLE

Admiral Ozawa's carriers and cruisers had performed their function bravely by drawing Halsey's 3rd Fleet away from Leyte, though all to no avail. Their destruction, which took place off Cape Engano, at the northern tip of Luzon, was inevitable—indeed, it formed part of the Japanese plan. The only use that remained for the once proud Japanese carrier force was as sacrificial victims.

It was as a response to his pilots' inability to damage enemy ships with conventional tactics that Admiral Ohnishi, commander of the 1st Air Fleet on the Philippines, called for volunteers to carry out suicide attacks. On October 21, off Leyte, a pilot flew his aircraft into the cruiser *Australia*. Four days later Ohnishi's Special Attack Unit, formally dedicated to kamikaze tactics, began systematic suicide attacks. On October 25-26 they crashed onto 47 US ships, including seven carriers. The first to be sunk by a kamikaze attack was the escort carrier *St Lô*.

The suicide attacks were a disturbing conclusion to an important American victory. By any measure it had been one of the largest sea battles in history, and the Japanese had lost. Their surface warships would take no further active part in the war, beyond a suicidal gesture at the very end.



No chance of escape
A Japanese heavy cruiser desperately maneuvers while US bombers send up plumes of water around it. The raid on Manila Bay was part of the American campaign to reconquer the Philippines after Leyte Gulf.